

Shivaji's Maratha connection too. The recent Lok Sabha elections saw it woo Marathas by offering tickets to Shivaji's descendants, Udayanraje Bhosale and Chhatrapati Sambhajiraje. State politicians call it an attempt to strengthen the party's base in western Maharashtra, the heart of the erstwhile Maratha Empire. NCP leader Vinayak Mete, who was suspended for attacking writer Kumar Ketkar because of a satirical piece on the memorial, has been reinducted into the party within a year. "The regionalisation of Indian politics

vide with hardliner Maratha groups trying to emphasise Shivaji's caste. While the Maratha Seva Sangh is objecting to the appointment of Babasaheb Purandare, a Brahmin, as the chief of the committee, the Maratha Mahasangh has threatened an agitation if the memorial includes Brahmin figures from history such as Ramdas Maharaj and Dadoji Konddeo, fearing that it will lead to "Brahminising the Maratha warrior". Palshikar explains, "The memory of Shivaji helps sustain regional pride. So parties follow a process of appropriation of the icon.

propagated by Brahmin scholars.

With assembly elections being scheduled for later this year, Shivaji's name is being whipped up once again to win support, a strategy that has been used from the pre-Independence era. Bal Gangadhar Tilak celebrated Shiv Jayanti to gather people and inspire them to fight for Independence; leaders of the Samyukta Maharashtra movement also used his name to garner support. Later, the Shiv Sena, which takes its name from Shivaji, also used the Maratha ruler to invoke Marathi *asmita*. Says Sanjay

- The Shiv Sena was formed in 1966 on the principles of the Maratha warrior. From 1995 to 1999, the Shiv Sena-BJP regime renamed the city airport and the erstwhile Victoria Terminus after Shivaji.
- In November 2008, the Sena launched the Shiv Vada Pav, a food chain to encourage young Marathi

entrepreneurs. The NCP alleged that the Sena was belittling the warrior.

- Political parties ransacked the Bhandarkar Oriental Institute in Pune while protesting against British historian James Laine's book on Shivaji as they felt that it insulted Marathi sentiments.

- In 2008, the state government renamed the Dadoji Konddeo award as the Best Sports Coach award after Maratha groups protested against highlighting the Brahmin tutor's influence.

- The Maratha Seva Sangh wants Babasaheb Purandare to be removed from the post of chief of

the Shivaji Memorial Committee as he is a Brahmin and had 'distorted' Maratha history.

- The NCP offered Lok Sabha tickets to Shivaji's descendants Udayanraje Bhosale and Chhatrapati Sambhajiraje.

- References to Dadoji Konddeo as the Maratha warrior's teacher were deleted from the Standard IV history text-book a few days ago. Saffron parties are protesting against this.



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over the last 30 years has seen parties fall back on symbols, historical figures and caste. They are capitalising on Shivaji's legacy since he is revered in the state," says Venkatesh Kumar, political scientist at Mumbai University.

Political observers claim that the recent controversy over who should head the memorial committee is a ploy to appropriate Shivaji's legacy ahead of the Assembly elections and cash in on Maratha pride by invoking his name. The battle has now taken the form of a Brahmin-Maratha di-

Every appropriator attaches a certain meaning to the memory of Shivaji."

It is believed that the scramble by political parties to stake claim to Shivaji is the result of decades of selective portrayal by intellectuals and politicians. The pre-Independence era saw an attempt to give the warrior a pro-Brahmin feel, leading to the popular phrase *Gow Brahman Prati Palak* (saviour of the Brahmin and the cow). In recent times, there has been an upsurge of Maratha groups who have refused to accept history as

Raut, spokesperson of the Sena: "Whenever there has been an agitation, Maharashtra has come together under Shivaji's name and it continues. There's no better way to connect with people." While the attempt to stake a claim to Shivaji may have grown manifold in the last few years, political parties are aware that it will not translate into votes. Says Mete: "How will it benefit any party when everyone is using his name?" Despite this, regional outfits continue to be locked in a battle of one-upmanship to grab a piece of his heritage. ■